

CONTROLLING OFFICER'S REPLY

HHB116

(Question Serial No. 1774)

Head: (140) Government Secretariat: Health Bureau

Subhead (No. & title): ()

Programme: (2) Health

Controlling Officer: Permanent Secretary for Health (Thomas CHAN)

Director of Bureau: Secretary for Health

Question:

On enhancing the Elderly Health Care Voucher Scheme, would the Government inform this Committee of the following:

- 1) the numbers of voucher claim transactions and the total amounts of vouchers claimed in the past 3 years, broken down by healthcare service provider;
- 2) whether there are plans to introduce Elderly Health Care Voucher for designated use for guiding the elderly to use healthcare services in a timely and appropriate manner. If yes, what are the details? If not, what are the reasons?

Asked by: Hon LAM Tzit-yuen, David (LegCo internal reference no.: 4)

Reply:

1.

The Government launched the Elderly Health Care Voucher Scheme (EHVS) in 2009. It aims at providing financial incentives for elderly persons to choose private primary healthcare services that best suit their health needs and providing them with additional healthcare choices on top of the existing public healthcare services. Currently, the EHVS subsidises eligible Hong Kong elderly persons aged 65 and over annually with Elderly Health Care Vouchers (EHCVs) at the amount of \$2,000 (accumulation limit of \$8,000) to use primary healthcare services provided by 14 types of healthcare professions¹.

The tables below show the number of voucher claim transactions, the amount of vouchers claimed and the average amount per claim transaction by types of healthcare service providers enrolled in the EHVS in the past 3 years:

¹ They are medical practitioners, Chinese medicine practitioners, dentists, nurses, physiotherapists, occupational therapists, radiographers, medical laboratory technologists, chiropractors, optometrists with Part I registration under the Supplementary Medical Professions Ordinance (Cap. 359), and audiologists, dietitians, clinical psychologists and speech therapists under the Accredited Registers Scheme for Healthcare Professions (AR Scheme).

Number of Voucher Claim Transactions

	2021	2022	2023 ^{Note 1}
Medical Practitioners	1 917 943	1 954 032	2 325 617
Chinese Medicine Practitioners	1 542 578	1 647 630	1 965 635
Dentists	308 343	288 532	331 342
Occupational Therapists	7 224	4 177	4 232
Physiotherapists	48 107	37 603	45 673
Medical Laboratory Technologists	20 033	14 593	15 441
Radiographers	19 373	20 761	22 659
Nurses	11 295	9 376	11 196
Chiropractors	9 357	8 841	10 331
Optometrists	196 046	161 156	230 239
Audiologists ^{Note 2}	-	-	784
Clinical Psychologists ^{Note 2}	-	-	2
Dietitians ^{Note 2}	-	-	609
Speech Therapists ^{Note 2}	-	-	5
Sub-total (Hong Kong):	4 080 299	4 146 701	4 963 765
University of Hong Kong - Shenzhen Hospital (HKU-SZH) ^{Note 3}	35 953	32 356	38 462
Total:	4 116 252	4 179 057	5 002 227

Amount of Vouchers Claimed (in \$'000)

	2021	2022	2023 ^{Note 1}
Medical Practitioners	1,027,990	1,059,052	1,270,495
Chinese Medicine Practitioners	788,617	854,324	1,140,988
Dentists	355,444	343,327	413,222
Occupational Therapists	7,503	4,518	4,455
Physiotherapists	19,238	17,743	22,726
Medical Laboratory Technologists	20,552	13,393	14,712
Radiographers	22,603	24,635	29,503
Nurses	11,049	9,878	11,168
Chiropractors	5,760	5,080	5,955
Optometrists	284,753	233,912	352,743
Audiologists ^{Note 2}	-	-	2,693
Clinical Psychologists ^{Note 2}	-	-	4
Dietitians ^{Note 2}	-	-	829

Speech Therapists ^{Note 2}	-	-	5
Sub-total (Hong Kong):	2,543,509	2,565,862	3,269,498
HKU-SZH ^{Note 3}	12,103	10,949	11,883
Total:	2,555,612	2,576,811	3,281,381

Average Amount of Vouchers per Claim Transaction (\$)

	2021	2022	2023 ^{Note 1}
Medical Practitioners	536	542	546
Chinese Medicine Practitioners	511	519	580
Dentists	1,153	1,190	1,247
Occupational Therapists	1,039	1,082	1,053
Physiotherapists	400	472	498
Medical Laboratory Technologists	1,026	918	953
Radiographers	1,167	1,187	1,302
Nurses	978	1,054	997
Chiropractors	616	575	576
Optometrists	1,452	1,451	1,532
Audiologists ^{Note 2}	Not Applicable	Not Applicable	3,435
Clinical Psychologists ^{Note 2}	Not Applicable	Not Applicable	2,000
Dietitians ^{Note 2}	Not Applicable	Not Applicable	1,361
Speech Therapists ^{Note 2}	Not Applicable	Not Applicable	1,000
HKU-SZH ^{Note 3}	337	338	309

Note 1: From 28 July 2023, the EHVS allows shared use of vouchers between two eligible elderly persons in spousal relationship upon their mutual consent and completion of procedures to pair up their voucher accounts. Besides, the three-year Elderly Health Care Voucher Pilot Reward Scheme (Pilot Reward Scheme) was launched on 13 November 2023 under the EHVS. Eligible elderly persons who have accumulated voucher spending of \$1,000 or more on designated primary healthcare services within the same year will be allotted \$500 reward to their voucher account for use for the same designated healthcare purposes, so as to encourage more effective use of primary healthcare services by the elderly.

Note 2: With effect from 28 April 2023, the coverage of EHVS has been extended to include primary healthcare services provided by 4 additional types of the healthcare professionals enlisted under the AR Scheme (i.e. audiologists, clinical psychologists, dietitians and speech therapists).

Note 3: The Pilot Scheme for use of vouchers at the HKU-SZH was launched on 6 October 2015 and has been regularised since 26 June 2019. The HKU-SZH joined the EHVS on a hospital basis. Starting from 17 April 2023, eligible elderly persons can use the vouchers to pay for the fees of outpatient healthcare services at the Huawei Li Zhi Yuan Community Health Service Center of the HKU-SZH.

2.

In accordance with the Primary Healthcare Blueprint (Blueprint) launched by the Government in December 2022, the Government will strive to direct resources towards primary healthcare services with an emphasis on strengthening chronic disease management and reinforcing the different levels of prevention. To tie in with the development direction put forward in the

Blueprint, the Government launched the three-year Pilot Reward Scheme in November 2023 to, through providing rewards, further incentivise elderly persons by guiding them to make better use of EHCVs for continuous preventive healthcare and chronic disease management services, etc., so as to achieve the original policy objectives of the EHVS by optimising the use of resources to promote primary healthcare and supporting the healthcare needs of elderly persons.

Under the Pilot Reward Scheme, elderly persons only need to accumulate the use of EHCVs of \$1,000 or more for designated primary healthcare purposes such as disease prevention and health management services within the same year (from January to December), and they will be automatically allotted a \$500 reward to their voucher accounts by the eHealth System (Subsidies), which can be used for the same designated primary healthcare purposes, without the need for registration. In other words, for elderly persons who met the above criterion and are allotted the reward, the amount of EHCVs they receive in that year is increased from \$2,000 to \$2,500.

The designated primary healthcare services under the Pilot Reward Scheme include:

- (1) Services on disease prevention and follow-up/monitoring of long-term conditions provided by medical practitioners, Chinese medicine practitioners and dentists enrolled in the EHVS, such as health assessment, body check, screening, vaccination, chronic disease management, dental examination, scaling, extraction and filling, etc.;
- (2) Hypertension and diabetes mellitus screening, as well as treatment phase services provided under the Chronic Disease Co-Care Pilot Scheme;
- (3) Personalised services and Community Rehabilitation Programme provided by District Health Centres/District Health Centre Expresses; and
- (4) Outpatient services on preventive and follow-up/monitoring of long-term conditions provided by 11 designated Outpatient Medical Centers of the HKU-SZH and the Health Centre operated by the HKU-SZH.

From mid-November 2023, when the Pilot Reward Scheme was launched, to end-December 2023, over 83 000 elderly persons have received the reward, and the number of voucher claim transactions used on the designated primary healthcare services was 307 628, accounting for 54% of the total voucher claim transactions during the same period, whereas that for the period between January 2023 and mid-November 2023, i.e. prior to the launch of the Pilot Reward Scheme, was 48%. This shows that the Pilot Reward Scheme has the effect of encouraging the elderly to use the designated primary healthcare services. The Government will keep closely monitoring the implementation of the Pilot Reward Scheme and evaluate its effectiveness in promoting the use of such services as health assessment, disease screening and chronic disease management by the elderly.

Hong Kong has one of the most rapidly ageing of population in the world and the pace of ageing will peak in the upcoming decade. The population aged 65 and over will increase from 1.45 million in 2021 to 2.74 million in 2046. Both the number of elderly persons using vouchers and the financial commitments involved will continue to increase substantially. Optimising the use of resources invested in the EHVS so as to achieve our objective to enable the elderly to make good use of their vouchers on primary healthcare services for disease prevention and health management is essential for enhancing the health of the elderly and the sustainability of the healthcare system. Continuing to increase or expand the EHCVs for undesignated and unguided uses for unmonitored healthcare services, and allowing use of

EHCVs for secondary/tertiary healthcare services would not be sustainable policy-wise and financially and is thus not on our policy agenda. We will continue to review the health benefits brought by the EHVS in planning for the future development of primary healthcare.

- End -